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ABSTRACT

Online dating offers users with different political affiliations opportunities to meet, triggering a growing need for political partner-vetting to maintain political homophily, as shared political affiliations hint that they have similar views on social affairs and similar moral foundations. Meanwhile, dating algorithms are likewise screening potential partners based on similarity matching. Therefore, there is a tension between users' beliefs in the algorithm's capacity to identify a compatible mate (defined as algorithmic belief) and their information-seeking behavior of partner-vetting. This study examines this association and its emotional outcomes among users with different mixed dating motivations. With the nationally representative data from the Pew Research Center, we clustered three motivational types of users: non-love seekers, long-term relationship (LTR) sticklers and balanced users. Non-love seekers' algorithmic belief is reversely related to political partner-vetting and excitement. LTR sticklers' algorithmic belief is positively associated with partner-vetting and worse emotional outcomes. This study highlights the negative effects of algorithmic beliefs in online dating, shedding light on how technology and politics work together to influence online intimacy.

KEYWORDS

Online dating; algorithmic belief; political homophily; motivation; dating app; relationships

Introduction

Over the past four decades, the two major political parties in the United States have become more ideologically divided and increasingly hostile toward one another (Iyengar et al., 2012). Political polarization has extended beyond policy debates and elections, now affecting everyday nonpolitical social interactions, even in shopping and sports events (Huber & Malhotra, 2017). This phenomenon of “the spillover of party-centric politics” (Engelhardt & Utych, 2020) has also been confirmed in the realm of romantic relationships (Iyengar et al., 2012; Martin et al., 1986; Nicholson et al., 2016), where people are inclined to seek romantic partners and spouses who share similar political views (Ali, 2024; Evans, 2019; OkCupid, 2025). This may lead to partners amplifying each other's political views. More importantly, the shared political affiliation then forms an “echo chamber” that causes intergenerational continuity and exacerbates polarization at the societal level (Iyengar et al., 2018; Rico & Jennings, 2016). However, if partners have different political

stances, lower relationship satisfaction and lower intention for political engagement are observed (Peacock & Pederson, 2022). Therefore, it is important to conduct political vetting of dating partners, which has been defined as a political information-seeking strategy (Chan, 2021, p. 706).

Meanwhile, online dating has gained immense popularity (Ali, 2024; Tinder, 2024a), with over 30% of American adults engaging in it (Gelles-Watnick, 2023). Online dating relies on algorithmic recommendations to increase the success rate of matches, and political affiliation is becoming increasingly important in this process (Carr, 2016). For instance, apps like The Right Stuff and Christian Mingle, explicitly cater to users of specific political alignments, making political congruence a core matching factor (Iyer, 2024). Tinder introduced the “Take Action Center,” allowing users to display political stickers on their profiles, which feed into matching algorithms (Tinder, 2024b). On OkCupid, whether to support Trump is one of the political matching questions (Iyer, 2024). In a context where dating platforms now

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incorporate political leanings into their matching systems, users' subjective beliefs in matchmaking algorithms influence their dating psychology and behavior. How confident they are in the algorithm's capacity to identify compatible partners is defined as algorithmic belief (Hu & Rui, 2023; Sharabi, 2021, 2022). It plays a central role in shaping users' expectations, but we do not yet know how technological algorithms and political partner-vetting interact online. These trusts in algorithmic capabilities may either reduce users' tendency to manually screen for political alignment or backfire by increasing disappointment when algorithmic matches violate those expectations.

Additionally, previous research has mainly explored the consequences of political factors on marital or parenting relationships (e.g., Iyengar et al., 2018; Martin et al., 1986; Peacock & Pederson, 2022; Yu et al., 2024). However, in online dating, people are not always long-term relationship (LTR) sticklers. Users may also carry motivations for sexual behavior, friends, and casual dating (Timmermans & De Caluwé, 2017). Therefore, it is necessary to examine the emotional outcomes of political partner-vetting during online dating.

To contribute to the literature on political affiliations and online dating, we conducted an exploratory study. First, we review the literature on partner political vetting and explore the role of users' beliefs about algorithm effectiveness based on Expectancy Violation Theory (EVT). We seek to examine the political partner vetting during online dating and its emotional responses of users with different dating motivations (e.g., LTR sticklers, etc.). Based on data from a nationally representative sample recruited by the Pew Research Center, this study investigates the relationship among algorithmic beliefs, political partner-vetting, dating motivations, and dating feelings, aiming to provide insights into partisan bias and outcomes in algorithmic dating.

Literature Review

Vetting partners' political affiliation in online dating

Relationships are often shaped by specific rules, with similarity being the most significant factor

(Buss & Schmitt, 1993). According to the attraction paradigm (Byrne, 1997), people's attitudinal similarity exists before attraction and determines attraction. Thus, a shared political affiliation has been shown to function as a screening mechanism in dating (Alford et al., 2011; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Schmitz, 2017) and exists in the process of choosing a partner (Chan, 2021). Iyengar and colleagues (2018) also confirm that political homophily is a pre-held screening criterion, rather than formed by mutual influence in relationships.

The significance of political homophily in studies of similarity and attraction stems from the view that political incongruence reflects not only differing electoral preferences but also conflicting views on social issues and deep moral and cognitive divides. Previous studies have found that people with different political orientations differ in their moral foundations (Kivikangas et al., 2021). Among the five moral foundations, liberals usually consider care and fairness to be more relevant to morality, while conservatives are in the habit of making moral judgments based on loyalty, authority, and sanctity (Chan, 2024; Kivikangas et al., 2021). This deep inconsistency ultimately manifests itself as people disagreeing on social issues such as abortion, gun legalization, and health insurance (Antiel et al., 2014). Thus, scholars test the effect of political homophily, indicating that its effect is substantial in scale, comparable to or even exceeding those of race and education (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Orth & Joyner, 2025).

Considered the cornerstone of political homophily in relationships, people's political partner-vetting, a necessary information-seeking behavior, appears to be common (Buggs, 2017; Chan, 2021). For example, Tinder, one of the most popular dating applications with 100 million active users worldwide, suggests that the mentions of supporting #BLM (Black Lives Matter) became a must for many users (Tinder, 2020). People present each other's political views in dating profiles and quickly screen out dissidents. This type of political partner-vetting, based on others' publicly available information, is one of the most straightforward and common strategies (Chan, 2021).

A strong preference for political homophily, or more political partner-vetting behavior, may

indicate a heightened focus on politics, which could lead to negative emotions. While political scientists acknowledge the positive impact of political participation, most of them focus on traditional activities such as signing community petitions or online activism (Foster, 2019), and this mechanism is thought to benefit from the social identity that comes with joining a political group (Foster, 2019; Vestergren et al., 2017). But in interpersonal interactions, particularly in dating and romantic relationships, excessive focus on politics can lead to stress and burnout. One study conducted four experiments and found that merely thinking about daily political events can trigger negative emotions and reduce participants' well-being (Ford et al., 2023). More studies show that exposure to political information was also associated with higher levels of burnout and lower levels of psychological well-being (Bird et al., 2024; Ortlund et al., 2025). According to Ford et al. (2023), while political events such as presidential elections are undoubtedly important, day-to-day politics can continue to provide chronic stress and negative emotions in a relatively stable manner, thus affecting people's well-being.

While partner vetting in online dating is not the same as daily political news consumption, it also offers insights into how partisan differences are evoked in everyday life, amplifying differences in values between individuals (Engelhardt & Utych, 2020). To reduce the anxiety from daily negotiation and conflict (Van Duyn, 2024), people have to be more engaged in partner vetting, while political information seeking driven by anxiety may further lead to more anxiety (Romanova & Hutchens, 2024). Thus, the H1 is postulated:

H1: Political partner-vetting is (a) negatively related to positive emotions and (b) positively related to negative emotions in online dating.

Algorithmic belief and dating experience

Most dating sites tout their complex algorithms as beneficial, claiming they offer "more compatible matches than traditional dating does" (Finkel et al., 2012). However, the algorithm in online

dating did not eliminate the people's artificial political partner-vetting. Buggs (2017) found that it was common to encounter dates with opposing political views, and users must always be prepared for more political polarization of issues such as gender, race, and even climate. It has also been found that political partner-vetting has transcended the American two-party politics and has emerged in online dating in other locations such as Hong Kong (Chan, 2021, 2024). So, how do users face the algorithmic program based on similarity matching, and possible political inconsistencies with a date?

The concept of "algorithmic belief" provides a beneficial perspective. Initially, this concept concerned people's interactions with algorithms on social platforms (Bucher, 2017), and began to gain traction in online dating recently (Hu, 2024; Hu & Rui, 2023; Sharabi, 2021). According to Sharabi (2021, p. 13), it refers to beliefs in algorithms' capacity to identify a compatible mate. One possible explanation is that algorithmic beliefs increase users' confidence in getting a good relationship with the assistance of the algorithm (Sharabi, 2021). One longitudinal study explores this concept and suggests that users' belief in the legitimacy of algorithms' effect on finding partners can create a "placebo effect," leading them to experience more positive romantic outcomes (Sharabi, 2021). In other words, the more effective people perceive match-making algorithms, the better they may feel about their relationship (Hu et al., 2024). The efficacy of the algorithm in finding their ideal partners was conceptualized as "algorithmic beliefs" (Hu & Rui, 2023; Sharabi, 2021).

However, expectancy violation theory (EVT, Burgoon, 2015) may indicate a negative result even if algorithmic beliefs may seem to benefit users. EVT posits that individuals form expectations about social encounters, and their emotional and evaluative responses are shaped by whether these expectations are confirmed or violated. Once people's expectations are less or not met, individuals are more likely to experience dissatisfaction or disapproval. In the context of algorithmic matchmaking, a high level of algorithmic belief implies that users place trust in the platform's ability to deliver matches aligned with their preferences and personal characteristics. This belief led

users to expect that the algorithm would match them with partners who share key values, including political orientation. However, as previous studies suggest, encountering mismatches—especially in core values like political ideology—is both common and emotionally salient in online dating contexts (Buggs, 2017; Chan, 2021, 2024). Furthermore, despite advances in technology, matching users' ideals with actual partner traits remains highly complex and error-prone (Joel et al., 2017). Thus, when such mismatches occur, people with higher algorithmic beliefs are especially vulnerable to expectancy violations, resulting in greater negative valence. According to EVT, algorithmic belief indicates higher expectancy and finally leads to a worse online dating experience. In light of this discussion, the competitive H2-H3 are proposed:

H2: Algorithmic beliefs are (a) positively related to positive emotions and (b) negatively related to negative emotions in online dating.

H3: Algorithmic beliefs are (a) negatively related to positive emotions and (b) positively related to negative emotions in online dating.

The tension of political vetting by humans or by algorithms

To avoid the tension between political partner-vetting artificially or automatically, users may alter their dating behaviors following their algorithmic beliefs, a kind of faith in the efficacy of the matching process (Sharabi, 2021). Algorithmic beliefs indicate how the users cede part of their agency in finding a date to the machine. Past studies suggest that people prefer to delegate decisions to machines, including algorithms, especially in a low-transparency condition (Candrian & Scherer, 2022). The algorithmic delegation exists due to their perceived precision, efficiency and objectivity (Beer, 2017; Christin, 2017; Hemmer et al., 2023). Likewise, in the online dating context, matching algorithms serve as a black box. The technology company only discloses metrics such as age, weight, and region, and will not explicitly include filters for political affiliation (Carr, 2016; Courtois & Timmermans, 2018). As a result, people with higher algorithmic beliefs may prefer to rely on the dating

algorithm for political vetting. To put it differently, if the algorithm's political vetting is opaque or absent, users with higher algorithmic belief might assume political similarity is assured, inhibiting their artificial partner vetting.

In addition to algorithmic delegation, the placebo effect of algorithmic beliefs may also reduce people's political partner-vetting. Previous research on algorithmic beliefs suggests that people's positive imaginations help them to construct social reality in a desirable direction (Hu & Rui, 2023). Hence, the importance of political homophily may also be constructed and subjectively perceived according to individuals' algorithmic beliefs. Sharabi (2021) found that users may make their dating behavior cater to their positive future belief based on an algorithm, and thus, the algorithmic belief plays a role in preventing cognitive dissonance (Sharabi, 2021). It may no longer matter what political stance the partners have; what matters is that the algorithm thinks they may fit. As a result, people may no longer be political partner-vetting because algorithmic beliefs convince people that political differences can be crossed. Taken together, the H4 is proposed:

H4: Algorithmic beliefs negatively predict users' political partner-vetting in online dating.

The moderating role of mixed dating motivations

Although algorithmic beliefs implicitly imply an expectation of better matching experience (Hu, 2024; Sharabi, 2022), users' motivations for online dating simultaneously shape it (Gibbs et al., 2006). Hence, it is necessary to combine users' algorithmic belief and their dating motivations. One common stereotype is that its primary motivation is casual sex (LeFebvre, 2018). However, studies suggest that online dating users may also prioritize monogamy and commitment despite the technological convenience of casual sex (Grøntvedt et al., 2020; Hobbs et al., 2017). Chan defined it as "a serious, meaningful and long-term relationship (LTR)" (Chan, 2017, p. 201).

Many studies have focused only on these two main motives (Chan, 2017; Sumter & Vandenbosch, 2019; Timmermans & Courtois, 2018). However, users' motivations may extend beyond the overly simplistic narratives mentioned

above. Previous research points to making friends as an important motivation for online dating as well (Brubaker et al., 2016; Corriero & Tong, 2016). Timmermans and Caluwé (Timmermans & De Caluwé, 2017) developed a motivation scale for Tinder use, suggesting more motives including casually dating, passing time and even forgetting about exes. These findings emphasize the heterogeneity and complexity of users' mixed motivations for online dating. Therefore, incorporating mixed dating motives is needed compared to a single motivational indicator.

Different motivations drive different political vetting behaviors and experienced emotions in algorithmic online dating. Users motivated by casual sex may prioritize immediate gratification and social interaction, often engaging with profiles that emphasize more superficial characteristics (Ranzini & Lutz, 2017). Consequently, they may be less focused on others' political information. Their algorithmic beliefs may more weakly predict political partner-vetting and emotions. But individuals highly motivated by LTRs tend to keep the same political views as their potential partners. They may also have high expectations that their online match will align with their self-categorization (Chan, 2021) when taking political homophily as a must. This may lead to stronger negative expectancy violations and more negative emotions. For other online dating motivations, the situation also varies. For example, some studies insist that friendship can create a protective environment for political dissenters (Finifter, 1974; Huckfeldt et al., 2002). It implies a weaker relationship between motivations for friends and users' vetting. But the opposing evidence also exists, where individuals are likely to engage with politically similar friends in online environments because political homophily can strengthen social connections and minimize potential sources of conflict (Buliga et al., 2021).

Considering the interweaving of multiple dating motivations and the challenges to existing hypothesized relationships, the following research question is formulated:

RQ: Does the type of user's motivation moderate

the association between algorithmic beliefs, political partner-vetting and emotions?

Methods

Data and sample

We utilize data from the 2022 Pew Research Center American Trends Panel Wave 111 (Pew Research Center, 2023), the latest public data on this topic. Pew Research Center was founded in 1990 and is primarily funded by The Pew Charitable Trusts. It is a nonprofit, nonpartisan, and nonadvocacy fact tank that focuses on public opinion polling (Pew Research Center, 2025). The Pew Research Center grants users a royalty-free license to use the American Trends Panel Survey for academic research purposes.

The survey topic focused on online dating and e-commerce in the U.S., conducted by the Pew Research Center in July 2022. National representative participants were recruited from the American Trends Panel and Knowledge Panel. Compared with past convenience sample studies, it is possible to reduce the errors caused by samples with high media literacy and education levels (Sharabi, 2021). Besides, the Pew Research Center data is not focused on one single dating app or website; as a result, it is believed to help produce more generalizable conclusions (Hu, 2024).

The Pew Research Center initially sampled 6,034 individuals and provided weights for each respondent to represent the entire American population better. However, since our study focused on online dating users, we only selected individuals who had dated online within one year, resulting in a sample of 951. We then removed observations with missing values for key variables, with a final sample of 839.

Variables and measures

Disappointment and *excitement*, respectively served as negative and positive emotions in this study. They both were measured using a single item in the Wave 111 survey: "In your personal experience

with online dating sites or dating apps over the past 12 months, have you ever felt . . .” “Disappointed in the people you have seen on these sites or apps” and “Excited by the people you have seen on these sites or apps” appeared in a random order and were captured on a three-point scale. The answers have been reverse-coded in this study (1 = No, I have never felt this way, 2 = Yes, sometimes, 3 = Yes, often). They were not combined into one variable due to the non-significance of the Pearson correlations ($r = -.05$, $p = .139$).

Political Partner-vetting was measured by a single item on a four-point scale: “When you have used online dating sites or dating apps, how important was it to you, if at all, that the profiles you looked at included the following?” Political affiliation was one of the sub-questions and appeared randomly with other items. Among people’s various political partner-vetting ways, the passive strategy of “observing others’ profiles” has the lowest risk (Chan, 2021, p. 202). Thus, we argued that this single item could reflect the most common and basic strategy for political partner-vetting. The answers have been reverse-coded in our study (1 = Not at all important, 4 = very important).

Algorithmic Belief, according to a previous study from Pew Research Centre (Hu, 2024), was measured by the item in the survey “Online dating sites and dating apps use computer programs, also called algorithms, to decide which profiles to show to someone. Do you think computer programs like these could determine whether two people will eventually fall in love?” Sharabi proposed and assessed the algorithmic belief with seven items (Sharabi, 2021), such as “Matching algorithms provide me with better quality partners,” and “I would trust a matching algorithm to find me a partner.” They all expressed the same meaning as the items in the Wave 111 survey. The answers in this study have been re-coded (1 = No, they couldn’t, 2 = Not sure, 3 = Yes, they could).

The types of users’ dating motivation were generated by cluster analysis. The Wave 111 questionnaire measured four main dating motivations using a 3-point scale: “to meet a long-term partner or spouse,” “to date casually,” “to have casual sex,” and “to make new friends.” These four dating motivations were presented in a random order. The answers in this study have been re-coded (1 = Not a reason, 2 = Minor reason, 3 = Major reason).

During the k-means clustering, the elbow method recommends three as the optimal number of clusters. Table 1 reports the dating motivations of the three groups. The first category is *non-love seekers* with 251 samples. They are mainly driven by casual sex ($M = 2.14$, $SD = 0.83$) and friendship ($M = 2.08$, $SD = 0.71$), and care less about romantic relationships: LTR ($M = 1.19$, $SD = 0.40$) and dating ($M = 1.80$, $SD = 0.73$). The second category is *LTR sticklers*, totaling 313 people. They only seek a stable partner or spouse ($M = 2.81$, $SD = 0.39$). Their motivations for casual dating ($M = 1.83$, $SD = 0.67$), casual sex ($M = 1.07$, $SD = 0.25$), and friendship ($M = 1.79$, $SD = 0.79$) are all below the average. The third and last category of users is relatively *balanced*, totaling 275 people. They hope to meet a long-term partner ($M = 2.52$, $SD = 0.53$), casual dating ($M = 2.82$, $SD = 0.42$), and casual sex ($M = 2.24$, $SD = 0.73$) at the same time, with a low level of motivation for friends ($M = 1.65$, $SD = 0.77$).

Control Variables: There is evidence that leftists (Orth & Joyner, 2025; Sleiman et al., 2023) and people who are more polarized (Goldenberg et al., 2022) place greater value on political homophily in dating. Considering that Internet use may be partly related to polarization (Osterbur & Kiel, 2021), frequency of Internet use, partisan leaning, and the degree of ideological polarization were included as control variables. Among them, *Internet use* (1 = Less often, 5 = Almost constantly) and *partisan leaning* (1 = Republican lean, 4 = Democratic Party lean) were assessed directly by single items in the survey. In addition, the survey collected participants’

Table 1. Motivation distribution of three types of users after K-means clustering.

Cluster:	Dating motivation items in the Wave 111 survey			
	A long-term partner	Casual dating	Casual sex	New friends
Non-love seekers	1.19 (0.40)	1.80 (0.73)	2.14 (0.83)	2.08 (0.71)
LTR sticklers	2.81 (0.39)	1.83 (0.67)	1.07 (0.25)	1.79 (0.79)
Balanced users	2.52 (0.53)	2.82 (0.42)	2.24 (0.73)	1.65 (0.77)

Note: Unstandardized mean and standard deviation (in parentheses) are reported. 1 = Not a reason, 2 = Minor reason, 3 = Major reason.

ideologies from 1 = conservative to 5 = liberal. Due to the multicollinearity with partisan leaning ($r = 0.83$, $p < .001$), we excluded this variable and calculated the distance from each respondent's ideology to the median (= 3). The further distance from the median indicates a higher degree of *ideological polarization*. Finally, demographic variables, including age, gender, race, income, and whether or not to live in the metropolis, were included as control variables. Due to the privacy policy of the Pew Research Center, the respondents' sexual orientation was not available and was therefore not included as a control variable. Details of all the variables are summarized in Table 2.

Results

Before hypothesis testing, we conducted a multinomial logistic regression using all control variables to assess whether demographic differences influenced the motivation type. The result showed that sex, income, metropolitan, and ideological polarization have significant effects (see Table S1). We checked for multicollinearity and found the variance inflation factor (VIF) always below 10. After confirming low multicollinearity,

a series of weighted grouped regressions was conducted to test the above research hypotheses and questions.

H4 assumes that algorithmic beliefs will negatively predict political partner-vetting. Table 3 showed that political partner-vetting was facilitated by Democratic partisan leanings and ideological polarization in all three groups. Algorithmic belief was significantly related to political partner-vetting in different motivation types, but in different directions. For non-love seekers, algorithmic beliefs negatively predict their political partner-vetting ($B = -0.31$, $SE = 0.08$, $p < .001$). However, the association was significantly positive for LTR sticklers ($B = 0.16$, $SE = 0.07$, $p = .023$) and users with balanced motivations ($B = 0.16$, $SE = 0.07$, $p = .023$). Therefore, algorithmic belief remained a significant predictor, but the hypothesized negative relationship appeared only among non-love seekers, supporting H4. For the other two groups, the direction was opposite to our prediction.

Table 4 suggested the weighted regression results for excitement and disappointment among each type. For non-love seekers (columns 1 and 4), algorithmic beliefs showed no significant association with excitement ($B = 0.07$, $SE = 0.05$, $p = .128$) or

Table 2. Descriptive statistics for all variables ($N = 839$).

Variables	Mean/Count	SD/%	Min	Max
Political partner-vetting	2.56	1.05	1	4
Disappointment	2.31	0.62	1	3
Excitement	1.94	0.54	1	3
Algorithmic beliefs	1.85	0.80	1	3
User type (based on motivation)				
Non-love seekers	251	29.92%	0	1
LTR sticklers	313	37.31%	0	1
Balanced users	275	32.78%	0	1
Control variables				
Sex = male	470	56.02%	0	1
Race = nonwhite	217	25.86%	0	1
Metropolitan	759	90.46%	0	1
Age				
18–29	242	28.84%	0	1
30–49	356	42.43%	0	1
50–64	181	21.57%	0	1
Above 65	60	7.15%	0	1
Education				
H.S. graduate or less	116	13.83%	0	1
Some College	265	31.59%	0	1
College graduate +	458	54.59%	0	1
Income				
Less than \$30,000	181	21.57%	0	1
\$30,000 to less than \$50,000	187	22.29%	0	1
\$50,000 to less than \$80,000	202	24.08%	0	1
\$80,000 or more	269	31.06%	0	1
Internet use	4.65	0.57	1	5
Democratic partisan leaning	3.02	1.10	1	4
Ideological polarization	0.90	0.75	0	2

Table 3. Weighted regression results of algorithmic beliefs on political partner-vetting ($N = 839$).

	Dependent variable: Political partner-vetting		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
	Non-love seekers	LTR sticklers	Balanced users
Algorithmic belief	−0.31*** (0.08)	0.16* (0.07)	0.16* (0.07)
Ideological polarization	0.40*** (0.08)	0.22** (0.07)	0.45*** (0.08)
Democratic partisan leaning	0.30*** (0.07)	0.16** (0.05)	0.13* (0.06)
Internet use	0.21 (0.12)	0.12 (0.11)	−0.04 (0.08)
Age	0.11 (0.08)	0.01 (0.07)	−0.02 (0.07)
Education	0.15 (0.09)	−0.16* (0.08)	0.03 (0.09)
Sex = man	−0.32* (0.13)	−0.18 (0.13)	−0.24 (0.13)
Race = white	0.13 (0.13)	0.06 (0.14)	0.33** (0.12)
Metropolitan	0.02 (0.18)	0.05 (0.19)	0.37 (0.26)
Income	0.08 (0.06)	0.04 (0.06)	−0.06 (0.05)
Weights	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	251	313	275
R ²	0.29	0.13	0.24
Adjusted R ²	0.26	0.10	0.21

Note. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$. Unstandardized coefficients and standard error in parentheses.

Table 4. Weighted grouped regression results for excitement and disappointment ($N = 839$).

Dependent variable:	Excitement			Disappointment		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Non-love seekers	LTR sticklers	Balanced users	Non-love seekers	LTR sticklers	Balanced users
Political partner-vetting	0.12** (0.04)	−0.06* (0.03)	0.01 (0.04)	0.05 (0.05)	0.14*** (0.03)	−0.02 (0.04)
Algorithmic belief	0.07 (0.05)	0.02 (0.04)	0.09* (0.04)	0.09 (0.06)	−0.18*** (0.04)	−0.05 (0.04)
Ideological polarization	−0.01 (0.05)	0.11** (0.04)	0.19*** (0.05)	0.22*** (0.06)	−0.06 (0.04)	0.17*** (0.05)
Democratic partisan leaning	−0.02 (0.04)	0.01 (0.03)	−0.06 (0.04)	−0.11* (0.05)	−0.08* (0.03)	−0.07 (0.04)
Internet use	0.01 (0.07)	0.01 (0.06)	−0.15** (0.05)	0.13 (0.08)	0.01 (0.07)	0.13** (0.05)
Age	−0.15** (0.05)	−0.07* (0.03)	−0.09 (0.05)	0.20*** (0.06)	0.08 (0.04)	0.12** (0.05)
Education	0.004 (0.05)	−0.01 (0.04)	−0.03 (0.05)	0.02 (0.06)	−0.07 (0.04)	0.09 (0.05)
Sex = man	0.34*** (0.08)	−0.05 (0.06)	0.03 (0.08)	−0.18 (0.09)	−0.16* (0.07)	−0.12 (0.08)
Race = white	−0.04 (0.08)	0.12 (0.07)	0.21** (0.07)	−0.15 (0.09)	0.001 (0.08)	0.06 (0.08)
Metropolitan	−0.44*** (0.11)	−0.14 (0.09)	0.23 (0.16)	0.003 (0.13)	−0.33** (0.11)	0.05 (0.16)
Income	0.07 (0.03)	−0.04 (0.03)	0.14*** (0.03)	0.09* (0.04)	0.02 (0.03)	0.05 (0.03)
Observations	251	313	275	251	313	275
R ²	0.16	0.08	0.23	0.17	0.18	0.11
Adjusted R ²	0.13	0.05	0.20	0.14	0.15	0.07

Note. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$. Unstandardized coefficients and standard error in parentheses.

disappointment ($B = 0.09$, $SE = 0.06$, $p = .108$). Hence, H2 and H3 were rejected. Political partner-vetting was unrelated to disappointment ($B = 0.05$, $SE = 0.05$, $p = .261$) but positively predicted

excitement ($B = 0.12$, $SE = 0.04$, $p = .003$), contrary to the negative emotional effect predicted in H1. Thus, non-love seekers' algorithmic beliefs indicated less political partner-vetting, predicting less

excitement. Further mediation analysis with 1,000 bootstraps confirmed this full indirect effect ($B = -0.04$, 95% CI = $[-0.02, -0.01]$, $p = .004$).

The results differed for LTR sticklers. Those who politically vet partners more reported less excitement ($B = -0.06$, $SE = 0.03$, $p = .032$) and more disappointment ($B = 0.14$, $SE = 0.03$, $p < .001$), supporting H1 (a)-(b). Algorithmic belief showed no significant association with excitement ($B = 0.02$, $SE = 0.04$, $p = .545$), rejecting H2(a) and H3(a). However, it significantly negatively correlated with their disappointment ($B = -0.18$, $SE = 0.04$, $p < .001$), supporting H2(b) but not H3(b). The results of mediation analysis suggested that political partner-vetting fully mediated the relationship between algorithmic beliefs and excitement ($B = -0.01$, 95% CI = $[-0.08, -0.02]$, $p < .001$). Political partner-vetting also partly mediated the relationship between algorithmic beliefs and disappointment ($B = 0.02$, 95% CI = $[0.03, 0.11]$, $p < .001$) despite a remaining negative direct effect ($B = -0.18$, 95% CI = $[-0.35, -0.19]$, $p < .001$).

Finally, for balanced-motivated users, stronger algorithmic belief predicted greater excitement during online dating ($B = 0.09$, $SE = 0.04$, $p = .043$), but showed no association with disappointment ($B = -0.05$, $SE = 0.04$, $p = .276$). Their political partner-vetting also did not correlate with feelings of excitement ($B = 0.01$, $SE = 0.04$, $p = .824$) or

disappointment ($B = -0.02$, $SE = 0.04$, $p = .541$). Hence, for balanced users, only H2(a) was supported. H1, H2(b) and H3 were all rejected.

To give a panoramic view, Figure 1 presents the variable relationships and indirect effects across the three cohorts. Besides, weighted regressions were conducted on the full sample to compare differences among clusters and answer the RQ (in Table S2). Interaction terms tested whether the differences were significant among different clusters. The results showed that both LTR sticklers ($B = -0.88$, $SE = 0.20$, $p < .001$) and balanced users ($B = -0.79$, $SE = 0.21$, $p < .001$) were less likely to engage in political partner-vetting compared to non-love seekers. Significant interaction effects indicated that the effects of algorithmic beliefs on political partner-vetting were different from those of non-love seekers for LTR sticklers ($B = 0.45$, $SE = 0.10$, $p = .002$) and balanced users ($B = 0.45$, $SE = 0.10$, $p < .001$). This suggested that the type of dating motivation did significantly moderate the relationship between algorithmic beliefs and political partner-vetting.

Discussion

To our best knowledge, this may be one of the first studies to examine the predictor (algorithmic beliefs), the outcome (disappointment and

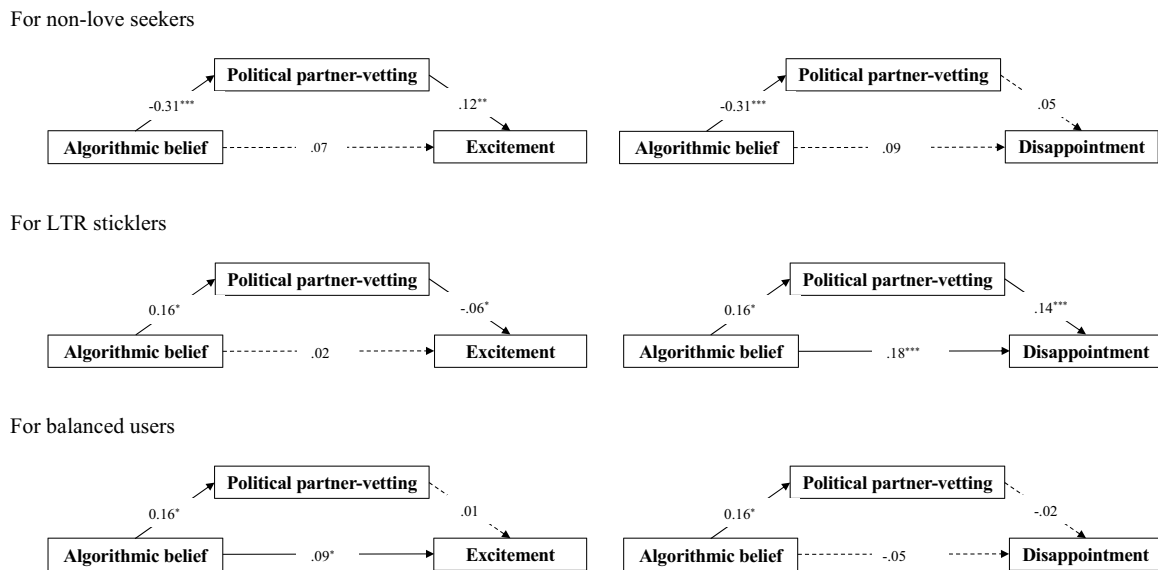


Figure 1. Variable relationships under different motivation types of users. Note. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$. The dashed lines in the figure represent non-significant relationships, and the coefficients are unstandardized, based on results in Tables 3 and 4. Control variables are included but not shown.

excitement), and the moderating mechanism (dating motivation types) of political partner-vetting in online dating. Our results revealed that political partner-vetting is differently influenced by algorithmic belief and affects emotional outcomes positively or negatively in different motivations. These findings need further discussion.

Previous research has highlighted the importance of political homophily in intimate relationships, suggesting that couples with differing political views are more likely to experience conflicts and experience some negative feelings (Alford et al., 2011; Peacock & Pederson, 2022). The present study expanded on this finding, indicating that simply vetting each other's political profiles online may increase disappointment and decrease excitement, but only in LTR sticklers. Dating and love are meant to foster connection, while political antagonism seeks to create boundaries between out-groups. Online dating allows individuals with different views to connect. Under the tension, LTR seekers are less likely to find compatible matches, leading to less excitement and greater disappointment, when they apply partisan antagonism to screen potential partners. For example, a Democrat may encounter a Trump supporter and feel angry and disappointed. Additionally, we also argue that politics in online dating functions as a form of "sexual capital," which is defined as attributes collectively perceived as attractive (Chan, 2021; Paik, 2016). Users with differing partisan biases may find those who share their political views more attractive. Vetting each other's political profiles serves as an assessment of sexual capital and threatens relationship success.

However, for non-love seekers, political vetting was positively associated with excitement. Political vetting may not be tied to their existential relationship goals. Instead, it becomes a curiosity-driven exploration or entertainment. This suggests that the logic of dating mediated by algorithm technology may prevail over the logic of politics. One interview study suggests that online dating users not only view algorithms as filters, but also have an algorithmic folk theory unique to online dating: games (Huang et al., 2022, p. 8), which emphasizes the entertainment value of the computer-mediated relationship initiation (Finkel et al., 2012). Such a gamified perspective implies that users may not

always treat online dating with seriousness, but with a gamified attitude. Thus, for these users seeking loose connections through online dating, political vetting may simply reinforce social identity, allowing them to indulge in the excitement of finding a like-minded partner and be less concerned about encountering an out-group they dislike. Thus, algorithmic belief describes a faith of algorithmic effectiveness in finding their ideal partners, but there is still a need to further refine this concept, and explore the roles that the algorithm plays when it works.

This study initially hypothesized that algorithmic beliefs could make people care less about political differences, or encourage people to rely on algorithmic similarity matching, and therefore reduce their artificial political partner-vetting. However, this speculation was only valid for non-love seekers. To put it differently, LTR sticklers and balanced users trust algorithms and thus engage themselves more in vetting. One explanation for this unexpected connection is that LTR sticklers' trust in the algorithm validates their belief that the platform may surface politically aligned partners, motivating a more active vetting. In addition, users who trust algorithms but encounter ambiguous or conflicting political cues experience cognitive dissonance (Harmon-Jones & Mills, 2019). To resolve this, they engage in deeper vetting to confirm alignment, reinforcing reliance on the algorithmic tools to affirm their worldview and self-verification (Lange et al., 2012). When they need to prevent political differences in a future LTR but highly rely on machine matching, they will further collaborate with the algorithm and conduct more vetting to affirm the effectiveness of the algorithm and dating websites or applications.

A series of past studies have pointed out the positive role of algorithmic beliefs in promoting dating experience and matching results (Hu, 2024; Hu & Rui, 2023; Sharabi, 2021). However, the results of this study point out its limitations. For non-love seekers and LTR sticklers, higher algorithmic beliefs will reduce the feeling of excitement through the full mediation effect of political partner-vetting. LTR sticklers with higher algorithmic belief will also conduct more political partner-vetting and report increased disappointment. Hu (2024) pointed out that the reason why algorithmic

beliefs can promote better dating experiences is that they can encourage online daters to construct a social reality that is consistent with their positive beliefs. However, this study indicates that algorithmic beliefs will also guide users to construct a social reality about political homophily, thereby achieving less excitement and more disappointment.

Theoretical and practical implications

This study makes contributions from a theoretical perspective. This study examines political partner-vetting in online dating and uncovers both the positive and negative effects of algorithmic beliefs in this process, thus contributing to the existing literature. This study challenges the evidence of an exclusively positive effect of algorithmic beliefs, finding that algorithmic beliefs may induce negative affective outcomes through political partner censorship. This suggests that algorithmic beliefs are not only related to beliefs about algorithmic effectiveness, but also need to be considered in conjunction with broader folk theories of online dating algorithms.

In addition, this study contributes to a better understanding of the politicization of online dating in the United States. Building on the concept of political partner-vetting, it finds that merely evaluating a partner's political profile can shape the dating experience. These effects vary by user motivation, revealing a complex interplay among motivations, beliefs, behaviors, and emotions. To further interpret these findings, we propose the mechanism of the “algorithmic leverage effect.” This effect suggests that users are not passive recipients of algorithmic recommendations; instead, they strategically adjust their reliance on the political vetting based on their dating motivations. For high-stakes pursuits, such as long-term relationships, users employ low algorithmic leverage, treating algorithms as assistants that require careful personal auditing to mitigate risks. Conversely, in low-stakes or casual dating, they apply high algorithmic leverage, delegating screening tasks to algorithms to maximize efficiency.

Furthermore, the finding that algorithmic belief can reduce political partner-vetting among non-love seekers carries broader implications beyond online dating contexts. It suggests that algorithmic trust

may serve as a delegation heuristic, whereby individuals offload political discernment to technological systems (Chen et al., 2025). This suggests the technological construction behind political homophily. In some entertaining scenarios under the “spillover of party-centric politics” (Engelhardt & Utych, 2020), algorithmic technology and beliefs have the potential to override political vetting, shaping individuals' political attitudes and behaviors.

This study also offers practical implications. With the nationally representative data, our findings can be generalized to the entire U.S. population, offering recommendations for online dating in the context of polarized politics. The findings of this study suggest that dating platforms can adopt more transparent, flexible, and user-controllable designs rather than hard-coding political similarity into their matching algorithms. Considering that the matching algorithms of major dating platforms are currently a black box, one possible practical suggestion is to offer users the option to indicate whether political compatibility is a priority, rather than assuming it is universally relevant. This would allow those who care deeply about political alignment (e.g., LTR stickers) to filter accordingly, while allowing others to explore more diverse matches.

Limitations and future research

The findings of this study need to be considered with its limitations. First, this study used secondary data from the Pew Research Center. Despite the nationally representative sample, it is cross-sectional, limiting us to making causal inferences. Also, our variables were measured on single items. While they can be accepted if the measured construct is narrowly scoped and clearly defined (Allen et al., 2022; Hu, 2024; Robitzsch, 2020), and they are common limitations in secondary data analysis (e.g., Hu, 2024; Wang et al., 2022), future research should consider using more scientifically robust measures to address the operational limitations of this study.

In addition, users may engage in different social practices on different platforms. Some platforms have become highly politicized not merely because of matching system (Priya, 2025), but due to users' voluntary disclosure of political identities in their

profiles, such as #Black Lives Matter, #Me Too, Opposition to Trump, etc (Ali, 2024; Evans, 2019; OkCupid, 2025). In this context, we believe that the findings of this study are also explanatory.

Finally, the online relationships may be related to more factors and more emotional outcomes. For example, people may experience romance, anxiety, jealousy, sweetness and boredom in relationship dynamics (Pan et al., 2023). More confounding variables and more emotions could be considered to further test the findings of this study.

Conclusion

In today's digitally networked and fragmented society, love is less bound by religious or traditional norms, but has become increasingly fluid and self-directed (Bauman, 2013). In such environments, individuals with different motivations bring their own beliefs, expectations, and strategies into algorithmic dating.

For users with different motivations, their algorithmic beliefs, political vetting, and dating experiences also differ. For non-love seekers, the belief in algorithms finding ideal partners conflicts with their manual political screenings, leading to decreased feelings of excitement. However, in the case of LTR sticklers, algorithmic belief can reduce disappointment directly. At the same time, it promotes political partner-vetting and finally causes a worse emotional outcome. This study suggests that online dating is not a utopia where people abandon socio-political factors and date for love or sex. On the contrary, people's understanding of technology, motivation, love, and politics shapes the ecology of online dating. Among them, the interweaving of algorithmic beliefs and motivations makes the tension of politics and love present a complex dynamic.

Disclosure statement

ChatGPT-4o and Grammarly were employed to embellish English writing.

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